

YOU CAN HEAL YOUR LIFE

by Louise L. Hay

The Big “So What” ???

First published in 1984, this was one of the pioneers in self-help books, and many of Hay’s ideas have since been used and expanded upon by self-help gurus and holistic healers. It provides **insights into the relationship between mind and body, and shows how limiting thoughts, beliefs and negative emotions affect us and are linked to our physical diseases.** The book has sold over 30 million copies and helped millions with Hay’s self-healing strategies and guides.



KEY QUOTES

“If we are willing to do the mental work, almost anything can be healed.”

“If you will do the exercises progressively as they appear in the book, by the time you have finished, you will have begun to change your life.”

Introduction



Hay wrote this book in the same way she takes a client through a private session or a workshop. Each chapter starts with an affirmation and includes one or more exercises or treatments. **This summary covers her key philosophies, ideas and approach, including an overview of the recommended exercises.** To apply the strategies, you will need to review the book in detail and apply the detailed instructions provided by Hay.

Hay's Beliefs And Philosophies

Here are some of Hay's key beliefs and philosophies that form the foundations of the book and her self-healing approach:

- "What we give out, we get back...Every thought we think is creating our future..."We are each responsible for all of our experiences."
- "The point of power is always in the present moment."
- "Everyone suffers from self-hatred and guilt...The bottom line for everyone is 'I'm not good enough'."
- "The only thing we are ever dealing with is a thought, and a thought can be changed."
- "We create every so-called illness in our body...Releasing resentment will dissolve even cancer."
- "Resentment, criticism, and guilt are the most damaging patterns."
- "We can change our attitude towards the past...To release the past, we must be willing to forgive."
- "We must be willing to begin to learn to love ourselves... When we really love ourselves, everything in our life works."
- "Self-approval and self-acceptance in the now are the keys to positive changes."

KEY QUOTES

The Source Of Your Problems



After working with so many clients, Hay found that the problems they are dealing with (body, relationships, finances, life in general) are rarely the real problem.

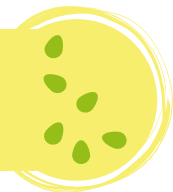
What is the problem?



The true problem almost always boils down to the fundamental belief that “I’m not good enough”, and the lack of self love.

For example, the underlying belief of financial disaster is often “I’m not worthy of having money”, that of having no friends is usually “nobody loves me” and the tendency to always try to please others often comes from the belief “I never get my way”.

Where does it come from?



These beliefs, along with many other ideas of who we are and the rules we must live by, are often learned when we are very young, from the adults around us. When we grow up, we tend to re-create our lives around these beliefs. Hay recommends several exercises, such as shifting “I should” to “I could” to realize we have a choice, identifying underlying issues beneath the visible problems, and identifying where some of our limiting beliefs come from.

As we become aware of underlying issues and their sources, we must be conscious not to lay the blame on our parents or others. Hay believes that we chose our parents to help us learn what we need to learn. We alone are responsible for how our life unfolds. Blaming others only means giving our power away.

KEY QUOTES

“Whatever we send out mentally or verbally will come back to us in like form.”

“Blame is one of the surest ways to stay in a problem. In blaming another, we give away our power. Understanding enables us to rise above the issue and take control of our future.”

Essentially, we are dealing with thought patterns. Once we recognize this, we realize **we have the power to begin change right now, at this present moment**. Since it all begins in the mind, **we also have full and complete control of the outcomes in our lives**.

Are Our Beliefs Even True?



Our beliefs (e.g. “boys don’t cry”, “you are not good at this”) **become our reality, hence we should examine if they are true to begin with**. Even if they were true in the past (e.g. don’t trust strangers as a child), they may no longer be true today. Learning to let go of false or old beliefs is a key to changing our lives.

How To Change



We start with a willingness to change, and by overcoming our natural resistance to change. Next, we learn to control our minds and thoughts, and to forgive ourselves and others.

1. Nurture the willingness to change



We must be willing to change on the inside before our outer circumstances will change. The process of healing begins the moment we begin to think about making a change. Hay details a **“willing to change” exercise** to identify the source of your resistance to change and use affirmations to release the resistance.

KEY QUOTES

“If a thought or belief does not serve you, let it go! There is no written law that says that because you once believed something you have to continue to believe it forever.”

“When the child within feels unsafe, it creates a lot of trouble... Be kind to yourself. Begin to love and approve of yourself. That’s what that little child needs in order to express itself at its highest potential.”



Reshaping our beliefs is like doing a **mental housecleaning**. We must remove old things to put in the new. Go through each of our mental rooms and examine the thoughts and beliefs, to decide which ones to keep and polish, and which ones

to throw out. **To change the deeply-buried patterns, we must first be aware of them.** Here are some forms of resistance to look out for:



Nonverbal cues e.g. changing the subject, falling sick, looking away, doing something else.



Assumptions e.g. “you wouldn’t understand”, “that won’t make a difference”, “my situation is different”.



Beliefs e.g. “It’s not right to do this”, “that’s too expensive”, “I’m not that kind of person”.



Them e.g. “God won’t approve of it”, “they won’t let me”, “my doctor doesn’t allow it”, “it’s against my upbringing/ religion”.



Self-Concepts e.g. I’m too old, young, weak, strong etc.



Delay Tactics e.g. “I’ll do it later”, “now is not the right time”.



Denial e.g. “it will go away”, “there’s nothing wrong”.



Fear e.g. “I might fail”, “what would others think?”.

Look out for these signs of resistance so you can release them (and push ahead with the changes anyway). **The crux is not about willpower or discipline; it is about the willingness to let go of the old/ past.** Note that **repeating patterns** highlight a need in us that must be addressed. **Self-worth and kindness to yourself support change**, while criticism of self and others don’t.

KEY QUOTES

Rather than work on ourselves, it is often easier to focus on what others need to change. “**Leave our friends alone**”, Hay says. People will change when they are ready; meantime, we can only focus on our own change.

2. Control the mind



Your mind is a tool that you can use in any way you want. **You are in control of your mind, not vice versa.** By controlling the mind, you can shape your thoughts and beliefs for the future.

Understand that the past is over and done; it cannot be changed and need not hold us back. **Physical release can also help to unlock pent-up emotions and past experiences.** For example, screaming with your windows closed or beating the pillows are both harmless ways to release pent-up anger.

3. Forgive yourself and others



Many people allow the past to hold them back; they cannot enjoy the present and future because of something that happened in the past. **The way to release the past is to forgive ourselves and others.**

Hay details **several exercises** to help us let go and release old patterns that have resulted in our current conditions or problems, and to forgive ourselves and others.

Building The New



Creating positive change is like planting seeds. It takes time for the seeds to sprout, and we need to constantly nurture the seedlings and keep the weeds away.

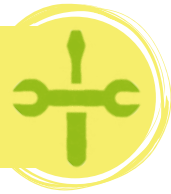
KEY QUOTES

“The way you now use your mind is only a habit, and habits, any habits, can be changed if we want to do so, or even if we only know it is possible to do so.”

“Love is always the answer to healing of any sort. And the pathway to love is forgiveness. Forgiveness dissolves resentment.”

“The more you dwell on what you don’t want, the more of it you create.”

Build on the Positives



What you place your attention on will grow. Hence, move away from negatives e.g. “I don’t want to be fat”, “I don’t want to be unhappy”; instead, focus on what you do be or have e.g. “I am healthy and slender”, “I am happy, joyous and free”. **Learn to think in positive affirmations** as a habit, using the present tense e.g. “I am”, “I have”.

As you start to observe your inner thoughts, you may notice negative thoughts - catch them in mid-sentence, rephrase them, drop them or tell the thoughts to “get out”.



Self-approval and self-acceptance are crucial for positive change:



Start with small things about yourself that you consider to be good qualities. Over time, you will learn to love and approve all of yourself, including qualities that you felt were not “good enough”.



Release ourselves from other people’s opinions: Each of us are unique, hence there is no need for competition nor comparison.



Put it to practice: Think and do things that make you and your body feel good (e.g. be with the right people, eat the right foods, think the right thoughts).

Hay provides several **exercises** in the book, including affirmations for self-approval, identifying negatives to be changed to positives, and developing positive beliefs that you deserve good things in life.

KEY QUOTES

“No matter what the problem, the main issue to work on is loving the self: this is the “magic wand” that dissolves problems.”

Holistic Philosophy



Hay advocates a holistic approach to nurture and nourish your entire being. This includes your Body (through nutrition, exercise etc.), your Mind (through visualization, affirmations, workshops etc.) and your Spirit (through prayer, meditation, practicing forgiveness and unconditional love etc.). Apply as many of these practices as possible, every day.

Daily Work



Changing your life is a gradual process that takes daily effort, and you will stumble along the way. Hay recommends several tips for **progressively building up the momentum for change**, e.g. beginning your day on a positive note, giving a few minutes daily to quiet meditation, doing daily affirmations etc. She also recommends several **exercises** to improve self-love, visualize the new you, and expand your knowledge.

Treat the process like how a child learns to walk - just keep going, judging your “failures”; Add on progressively and remind yourself frequently that you are doing the best you can.

Putting the Ideas to Work



For each of these areas, Hay recommends how we can apply the ideas above, including affirmations and exercises that can be used:



Relationships:

We attract the people in our lives; they are a mirror of our qualities or beliefs about relationships. If there's something you dislike about someone, start by asking how you are like that, and when do you do similar things. When you remove your own patterns

KEY QUOTES

“Relationships are mirrors of ourselves. What we attract always mirrors either qualities we have or beliefs we have about relationships.”

“Love is never outside ourselves; love is within us.”

and habits, that other person will either change, or he/ she will leave your life. Likewise, with love, don't hunt for it; When we love ourselves and are loving and receptive to love, we will attract people who have similar qualities.



Work:

You are in your work situation because of your own thinking patterns. Identify the areas of work you wish to improve (e.g. salary, colleagues), bless it, and affirm what you wish to create.



Success:

When something doesn't turn out the way you envisage it, it does not mean it is a "failure"; it merely provides the learning experience you need. Hay provides a series of success affirmations to help us plant the "seeds of success".



Prosperity:

Prosperity starts with our inner state of mind. We need to examine our beliefs about money, our beliefs about whether we "deserve" to prosper, and be willing to clear out the old to make room for the new. Love and bless your bills (don't dread them) as an acknowledgement of your ability to pay.

The Body



How we think and speak leads to our bodies' "eases" and "dis-eases". We create every dis-ease in our body due to our own thought patterns. Hay explains how some of these conditions come about, and how to listen to what our body is telling us through its dis-eases and discomforts, including headaches, baldness, sore throats, arthritis, back problems, heart attacks, cancer, ulcers etc.

The book includes an additional 60 pages of detailed Probable Mental Patterns (from Hay's book *Heal Your Body*) that cause

KEY QUOTES

"The law of experience is always perfect."

"True prosperity... is never an amount of money; it is a state of mind."

"The body, like everything else in life, is a mirror of our inner thoughts and beliefs...Every cell within the body responds to every single thought you think and every word you speak."

illnesses and suggested affirmations or thought patterns that can be used to create health instead. Essentially, patterns of thought relating to resentment, criticism, guilt and fear are the main contributors to our so-called illnesses. Forgiveness and releasing these thought patterns (alongside healthy nutrition and care for our body) are the key to wellness.

Additional Notes from Summary Author

This book may not be for everyone, as it is strongly anchored in New Age concepts and alternative healing methods. But for those who are open to such concepts, the book provides a detailed, step-by-step guide to start uncovering personal limiting beliefs and negative thoughts, and to start making positive changes.

It was not possible to capture all the suggested affirmations and exercises, nor the long list of illnesses and their likely corresponding “mental blocks”. If Hay’s ideas and concepts resonate with you, I suggest you pick up a copy of the book, as you will definitely refer to it many times in the course of applying these techniques. The book also includes a list of additional holistic healing resources, and you can get more updated resources on www.louisehay.com.

KEY QUOTES

‘Your security is not your job, or your bank account, or your investments, or your spouse, or parents. Your security is your ability to connect with the cosmic power that creates all things.’